



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-148
FIRST IN COUNCIL
August 3, 2026

COUNCILLOR ZUSY
COUNCILLOR AL-ZUBI
COUNCILLOR FLAHERTY

- WHEREAS: The City of Cambridge relies on coordinated work across multiple departments to review, approve, advise on, and manage booming business and residential development, including renovations, demolitions, and new construction; and
- WHEREAS: Departments, including but not limited to Inspectional Services, Community Development, Public Works, the Urban Forestry Division, the Fire Department, the Water Department, and the Historical Commission, are integral at ensuring development occurs safely, protects infrastructure, and minimizes disruption to the surrounding community; and
- WHEREAS: Homeowners and developers regularly navigate complex and interdependent processes requiring direction, review, or approvals from multiple departments, yet there is currently no clearly communicated workflow outlining the complete sequence of steps, responsibilities, timelines, and review criteria; and
- WHEREAS: Constituents remain unclear on how the development process works, which contributes to confusion; and
- WHEREAS: Improving communication within the City, and then outwardly to community members, will support responsible and much-needed housing creation by reducing delays, setting clearer expectations, strengthening coordination, and ensuring that projects advance while respecting neighbors and upholding City standards; and
- WHEREAS: City departments would benefit from a more structured, predictable process for sharing information, coordinating reviews, and publicly sharing data; and
- WHEREAS: While the pending “Neighbor’s Guide to the Multifamily Housing Ordinance” will provide helpful general information, a broader effort is needed to reflect internal workflows and provide developers and residents with a clear, step-by-step explanation of how projects move from initial inquiry to permit issuance to construction oversight; now therefore be it
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to convene all departments involved in permitting, reviewing, advising on, or overseeing building related activities to develop a coordinated, transparent, and consistently communicated process outlining:
- a point of contact from the City and for each project

- the full sequence of permit and review steps for altering, constructing, or demolishing a building
- the responsibilities of each department, including points of interdepartmental coordination
- the requirements and responsibilities for developers and property owners at each stage of review
- the expected timelines and decision points within the process
- mechanisms for notifying abutters and community members
- the consequences of noncompliance and how issues or complaints should be addressed
- clarification on City and state responsibilities and communication; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager further be and hereby is requested to produce a publicly accessible resource that clearly communicates this interdepartmental workflow to residents, and developers, ensuring that all parties understand the process from start to finish; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager report back on progress and preliminary recommendations to the appropriate Council committee at the September 14th Council meeting.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-



Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

Greater Interdepartmental Coordination and Community Information Sharing Relating to Development.